After the ExCom meeting, when the brothers left the Cabinet Room with its tape recorder, they moved to the Oval Office, where John Kennedy shared with Robert, Ted Sorensen, and his appointments secretary, Kenneth O'Donnell, his concerns about the danger of "miscalculation—a mistake in judgment." According to the account presented in Robert's memoirs, John once again brought up Barbara Tuchman's *Guns of August*. "They somehow seemed to tumble into war," he remarked, "through stupidity, individual idiosyncrasies, misunderstandings, and personal complexes of inferiority and grandeur." In an earlier draft of Robert Kennedy's summary of the discussion, there was no mention of *The Guns of August*. Instead there was a passage on World War I: the president considered the guarantees given by Britain to Poland in 1939 to have been a mistake. Like his father in 1939, John Kennedy believed that Britain should not have gone to war. In the current crisis he did not want the United States involved in any international agreement or arrangement of its own making that would automatically lead it into war.[10]

After the meeting was over, Robert Kennedy went to see Dobrynin in order to ensure that there would be no misunderstandings.

◊◊◊

IN MOSCOW, NIKITA KHRUSHCHEV WAS STRUGGLING WITH his own dilemma: he could not allow the Americans to search his ships in international or Cuban waters without looking weak, but neither could he afford a military confrontation in the Caribbean, being well aware that in case of an American invasion of Cuba, it would be difficult if not impossible to prevent the use of nuclear weapons. His solution was quite simple: to accelerate the passage of those ships that could reach Cuba before the start of the blockade and turn back those that could not.

The orders, issued in the morning of October 23, Moscow time, were received by ships in the Mediterranean about the same local time. The captain of the dry cargo ship *Mednogorsk* received his orders to turn back at 10:15 a.m. on October 23. The order came in the form of a coded telegram from the minister of the Soviet merchant fleet, Viktor Bakaev. The